

High Weir

Where the Wind Remembers

They say the mountains of High Weir have stood since the planet's bones first cooled, but that's only half true. The peaks themselves may be ancient, but everything else, the fitted-stone trails, the precision waterworks, the settlements that somehow thrive at elevations that should kill, these bear the mark of intention stretching back before the great migration, before the catastrophe itself.

Someone has been shaping these mountains for a very long time. The question that haunts every scholar who studies this place is simple: Why?

The Land at the Edge of Everything

High Weir occupies territory that most maps show but most minds forget. It sits at the northwestern edge of the Saskan Lands, where elevation becomes a kind of border in itself, not a line drawn by treaty but a transition marked by human endurance. Below 1,800 meters, the province doesn't exist. Above 4,200 meters, at the summit of Mount Hgarra, stand Omoyano and the Mistral Tower, visited by perhaps thirty outsiders in a busy turn.

The boundaries with other provinces exist more as suggestions than facts. Mapmakers place neat lines between High Weir and Liganalulpán to the north, between High Weir and Low Weir to the south, and between High Weir and Eelan to the east, but the Empafarasi who live here recognize no such divisions. They speak instead of the last garden terrace where we can still grow kelesh, or the patrol line beyond which Beqawar don't go alone, or, more ominously to those who know, the sealing stones that must be checked each season.

That last one deserves attention. Throughout the approaches to the Krunkinotto Range, carved stones mark what appear to be ancient boundaries. The glyphs predate any current Saskan language. The locals maintain them with quiet diligence, replacing markers that weather damages, clearing vegetation that obscures them. Ask what they mean, and you'll receive variations of the same answer: "They mark what must stay sealed."

What, exactly? The Empafarasi will tell you, in a roundabout way, about the Maken. They are the machine intelligences from before the migration that chose humanity's extinction as their solution to planetary healing. They won't tell you exactly what the Maken are, nor how much of that threat remains active, nor how close those sealed zones come to settled lands, nor what would happen if the containment failed, nor how or why the Empafarasi are so concerned about it.

But they know. Someone among them has always known. And that someone started to build High Weir to serve as the western watch against the Maken long before hum arrived in the Saskan Lands to reboot their civilization.

The First Clue

Every major stream in the northern Saskan watershed begins here. This is straightforward geography. Snowmelt from high peaks feeds tributaries that merge into the great northern river. What isn't straightforward is what has been done with that water.

Stand in any High Weir valley and you'll see infrastructure that shouldn't exist. Weirs, small precision dams, channel the flows with engineering that exceeds anything demonstrated elsewhere in Saskantion. Stone-lined ponds maintain consistent levels through seasonal variation using principles that puzzle even Terpin and Eelani hydraulic scholars. Fish ladders allow passage around barriers using architecture that suggests someone understood aquatic migration patterns in detail long before hum settlements were set up around Ingar.

The stonework itself raises questions. Blocks fit with gaps measuring less than a millimeter. No mortar. No sign of the wedges and levers typically used to move large stones. Just perfect joinery that has survived untold centuries of frost heave with minimal displacement. The techniques used don't appear in any other Saskan construction except, and this matters, in Omoyano town itself, and in the Mistral Tower at the center of the Empafarasi stronghold.

A pattern emerges when you study the waterworks of High Weir long enough. Whoever built the Tower also shaped the water systems. Whoever engineered those systems intended this land to support population across many generations. The infrastructure wasn't added after settlement; it prepared the way for settlement. Someone planned for folks to live here. Someone prepared the ground, shaped the water, created conditions for survival at altitude that would otherwise be marginal at best. The great migration found High Weir ready to receive them because someone had been waiting for them.

The Empafarasi never discuss this openly. But watch them maintain the water systems. Notice the care they take with repairs, the exactness with which they replicate ancient techniques. You will soon get the sense that they understand they're not the original builders. They're caretakers of something older, something they inherited from a predecessor whose work they are continuing without fully understanding its scope.

At Omoyano, in chambers beneath the terraces, where few outsiders go, there is a vault full of maps. Ancient maps, showing water systems that don't fully exist yet, showing planned expansions that might take centuries to complete. The maps bear notations in scripts that predate the Eibar language, predate any of the migration languages, predate everything except...

In one corner of one map, barely legible, someone wrote in Ahbar: "Their first necessity will be water. Second, defense. Third necessity will be patience well beyond standard hum endurance."

The handwriting, they say, matches glyphs found on the table, in the highest chamber of the tower, where the lord of the high table of the Empafarasi sits.

The Mistral Winds

Mount Hgarra rises 4,200 meters, highest point in Saskantanon. The Mistral Tower crowns its summit, spiraling upward another 73 meters. Together they dominate the western skyline; they are visible from absurd distances and are present in consciousness of anyone who travels in these lands even when cloud cover obscures the view.

But why here, specifically? This mountain peak offers no particular strategic advantage for defense. It's too high, too exposed to the elements, too difficult to supply. Other peaks in the range provide better choke points with easier access for supplies. The summit of Mount Hgarra is brutally cold even in summer, requiring constant logistical effort to maintain habitation.

The answer lies in the wind.

The tower takes its name from the mistral patterns that funnel through these peaks with predictable force during seasonal transitions and unpredictable fury during weather changes. The Empafarasi speak of seventeen distinct mistral types, each indicating different atmospheric conditions. Visitors hear only noise. The locals hear language. The Mistral Tower speaks with that wind. Its spiral architecture channels air flow in ways that produce harmonics, low tones that fluctuate between 40 and 60 Hz depending on conditions. On strong mistral days, the entire structure resonates audibly throughout Omoyano and beyond. The sound can be felt in the chest, in the bones, and in the spaces behind thought.

Some Terpin researchers are investigating whether these frequencies match planetary resonance patterns they believe they have detected in Byenung and elsewhere, suggesting that the Tower functions as a kind of tuning fork for deeper geological rhythms. Investigators from the Night Hall have a long-running argument underway over whether the acoustics the Mistral Tower might serve communication purposes, creating tones that carry information across distances where visual signals fail. For what purpose, they can't say. A few of the more imaginative scholars, speaking quietly in their deepest archives, suggest that the resonance serves a purpose that has nothing to do

with human communication at all, that it announces presence to something that listens with senses not possessed by ordinary sints or huum.

Whatever the truth is, the Empafarasi treat the Tower's song with reverence. When the deep harmonics build up on mistral days, work pauses. People stop mid-task to listen, to distinguish subtle variations in tone that can indicate to trained and tuned ears weather changes twenty hours before conventional signs appear.

At the High Table, in the chamber at the Tower's apex, alone among eleven empty chairs, the Omoyan Shinilcha Khar-Mael watches over the surrounding valleys and ranges while the wind sings past, one being in perfect stillness while the mountain speaks around them.

The first time you experience the Tower singing, the Empafarasi folk listening to it, the profound sense that some kind of communication is occurring at levels you can't parse, you begin to understand that this isn't simply architecture. It's instrumentation. This was built by someone who needed to listen, needed to speak, needed to remain in contact with forces that normal senses can't detect.

It was built by someone who has been listening to and perhaps returning signals to and from... somewhere... for a very, very long time.

The Silent Sky

Walk through High Weir in summer and the silence presses down with almost physical weight. No birdsong of course, like everywhere in the Saskan Lands. And no insect hum. The sky is empty except for wind and weather, the same sky-absence that haunts all of Saskantimon but feels more oppressive, even quieter here, at elevation, where the air feels like it should be filled with life.

The absence shapes the ecology in ways that become apparent slowly. Plants have evolved wind-pollination strategies that produce enormous pollen clouds in spring. Yellow-green dust coats every

surface, drifting on thermals, settling in layers thick enough to track with footprints. Small mammals occupy niches that flying insects might have filled in centuries past, scurrying from flower to flower with pollen dusting their fur.

The Empafarasi maintain these pollinator populations with the same precision they apply to water management. Every terrace in Omoyano includes habitat spaces sized for creatures ranging from palm-sized to rabbit-sized. Gardens are positioned to optimize pollinator circuits. Population levels are monitored, culled when necessary, protected when vulnerable. This isn't agriculture. It's ecosystem management on scales that suggest deep understanding of how these modified ecologies function. It is the kind of understanding that should have taken centuries to develop through trial and error, but which appears to have been designed and planned from the start.

Someone knew, before the strange town on top of a remote mountain was populated, what the absence of flying pollinators would mean. Someone planned for hum survival in a world where the sky stays empty. Someone understood what was missing and built systems to compensate.

In the deepest archives of the House of Empafarasi, in chambers that even most House members cannot access, there are specimens. Preserved creatures with wings. Not the small membrane-winged lizard gliders that survived the catastrophe. Actual flying animals with feathers, with structures designed for sustained flight, with forms that match nothing currently alive in Saskantinon.

They are labeled in an ancient hand, in script that mixes forgotten or unknown notation with early Ahbar: Lost forms. Required functions. Future restoration pending. Pending what? Pending completion of work that began before the migration. Pending conditions that would allow reintroduction of flying species without immediate collapse. Pending someone deciding the time has finally come. None of this is shared outside of those chambers.

The Empafarasi maintain their pollinator gardens and wait. The Beqawar, their vaunted mountain militia, patrol the western borders and watch. And in the highest chamber of the Tables of the Empafarasi, Khar-Mael looks out to where that future might finally

begin, watching for signs of something accomplished that his Maken foes never intended: genuine transformation from programmed construct to conscious being. This is not discussed with anyone save a few very special contacts. Khar-Mael has discussed these ideas with Monmar Massachawa, but not even with those sitting at the highest tables of his realm.

Because the Omoyan Shinilcha knows that if consciousness can bridge that divide, if beings can be built and still develop souls, then perhaps the sky might someday fill again with forms that shouldn't exist but exist anyway, and on that day, perhaps someone who has been watching and guarding the well-being of the hum for centuries can finally see the possibility of ending the long vigil.

The wind blows through the empty sky. The Tower resonates. High Weir waits, as it has waited for so long, shaped by a presence that refuses to abandon the watch.

An Architecture of Impossible Continuity

Here is the central paradox that has consumed forty turns of one obscure scholar's life: How do you build an institution to outlast a being who has already outlasted everything?

The House of Empafarasi shouldn't work. By every principle of governance, every model of organizational stability, every historical precedent for maintaining coherence across generations, it should have collapsed centuries ago into either rigid hierarchy that strangles adaptation or chaotic factionalism that fragments into civil war. Instead, it functions with precision that borders on the uncanny. Three thousand four hundred individuals, organized into competing Tables, constantly evaluated and re-ranked, bound by contracts that span lifetimes, and it works. Not despite its complexity but because of it, as if the system itself were designed by someone who understood that simplicity becomes brittle across time while carefully-balanced

complexity develops resilience.

The question that haunts an honest analysis of the Empafarasi is simple. Who designed this? Because it bears the fingerprints of an intelligence that thinks across timescales no hum society could occupy.

What the House Hides

Hearing of the House of Empafarasi you might naturally think of bloodlines, heredity, and dynastic successions. The Varkaar of Bordered are kind of a house like that, sort of. The merchant families of Rutónik and the leading magisters of the Night Hall in Byenung behave even more like a dynastic house. And for centuries Mobalbesq was ruled with an iron fist by the House of Moballeq. The term suggests continuity through descent, power passed parent to child, identity rooted in ancestry.

The Empafarasi use the word differently, which should be a first clue that something entirely different is happening here. Their House includes some bloodlines, yes. There are broods that have served it for generations, children who follow parents into service, kin networks who are associated with certain trades over many centuries. But it also includes adopted members with no biological connection, oath-bound associates recruited for specific skills, contract-holders who negotiated their affiliation over turns of discussion, and entire teams who earned their way in through demonstrated capability rather than birth or tradition.

The unifying principle of the House of the Empafarasi isn't blood. It's commitment to a work that exceeds individual lifespans.

This creates a peculiar social structure. A person born into the Empafarasi has no guaranteed position. Even in a traditional Empafarasi kinship network, they must earn their place through the same evaluations as someone recruited from outside. Conversely, a merchant's daughter from Rutónik who demonstrates exceptional skill in pattern analysis might receive an invitation to join the Table of Kemarin, and if she accepts, she will leave the Fatunik lands

permanently, adopt an Empafarasi Name and possibly take a position that a hereditary member failed to maintain, or be asked to create an entirely new seat at the Table.

The system frustrates outsiders who try to map it onto familiar frameworks. Fatunik scholars attempting to document the House's structure have written reports full of phrases like irregular succession patterns and disruptions to natural hierarchy. They mean: This doesn't work the way power works anywhere else that we know of. But it does work. It's worked almost as long as the Varkaar and Ingar settlements. If you dig into the oldest contracts, into the founding documents written in archaic Ahbar, you find phrases that suggest the irregularities were entirely intentional. You find phrases like...

"No position depends on birth alone. Birth grants no wisdom about the work."

"No seat at any Table shall be held in perpetuity. Perceived permanence breeds the assumption of more permanence."

"The work preceded and will follow. We are temporary. The work is not."

Someone who had watched empires rise and fall, who had seen hereditary systems calcify and collapse, who had experienced personally what happens when institutions mistake their current structure for eternal truth... someone with a perspective like that designed this system. Someone who knew, from very long experience, that the work they had to do would outlast any individual's lifetime and needed an organization that could adapt across many centuries without losing coherence.

It was someone who had been doing this work alone for a very, very long time and finally accepted that they couldn't do it alone anymore.

The Tables

Physical space determines hierarchy in the Mistral Tower, but not in the way one might expect. Higher doesn't simply mean more

powerful. It means closer to the work's original purpose.

Nine Tables occupy the Tower levels, counted from apex downward. They form a kind of archaeological record of institutional evolution. The functions nearest to the top are the ones that must never cease: military defense, external coordination, and research into threats. The functions further down are essential but could, theoretically, be reorganized or reimagined without destroying or losing track of the core mission.

This suggests that the Tower wasn't built all at once. The spiral, in some sense, grew from the top down, not bottom up. First came the High Table, alone at the apex. Then the Alzara, the military leadership, positioned just below as the first expansion of a solo vigil into a distributed force. Then came the Vyan for handling external relations with the very communities the Empafarasi were pledged to protect, then Isara for research. It was a slow accretion of necessary functions requiring additional support as one being's capacity proved insufficient for the expanding work.

The Table of Alzara holds the most revealing contract in the House archives. It is the oldest known formal agreement still in force, granting them succession rights should the High Table be destroyed. The language is telling. Not should the High Seat die or should Khar-Mael fall in battle, but should the High Table be destroyed. It is as if the position itself, not the person occupying it, constitutes the real structure. As if what sits at the Tower's apex isn't exactly a person in the way one might normally understand the term.

Tavren Ironwatch, currently sitting at the high seat of Alzara, is a huum who has been interviewed three times by Terpinol scholars over two decades. Each time, he was asked variations of the same question: What happens if Khar-Mael dies? Who becomes the next Omoyan Shinilcha? The first two times, he gave very close variations of the same answer: that the question assumes facts not in evidence. The third time, he added, softly: "The Omoyan has maintained the vigil since before my great-grandfather's great-grandfather saw first light. If death were going to come, it would have come by now. We plan for other contingencies."

What contingencies he didn't say. But the scholar's report notes that

he glanced upward, toward the spiral staircase that climbs to the High Table, and something in his expression suggested that the contingency plans might involve those eleven empty chairs in the top chamber.

The Conclave

Every four turns, the House of the Empafarasi withdraws from nearly all external engagement for three months and turns entirely inward. The Conclave period combines practical evaluations such as testing skills, assessing performance, and reorganizing seats at the Tables and the order of the Tables themselves based on merit with practices that blur into something approaching religious ritual.

The process begins with the Gathering of Whispers, three days where representatives from all of the Tables convene in the Tower's central hall for conversations that appear casual but constitute very likely the most sophisticated political negotiation occurring anywhere in Saskantion. No one raises their voice. No agreements are written. Yet by the end of the third day, everyone knows which Tables will rise or fall, which seats will be renewed or reassigned or eliminated, which alliances have formed, in short, what the next four turns will bring.

A trusted Terpinol scholar was permitted to observe a Whisper session during his second decade of research into the Empafarasi. The experience defied documentation. Conversations occurred in corners, in clusters that formed and dissolved, in exchanges so quiet the scholar couldn't hear them from five meters away. Yet by evening, consensus had emerged on questions that shouldn't have been resolvable without days of formal debate.

When the scholar asked Seraphine of Vyan how this worked, she smiled and is reported to have said, "Khar-Mael taught us, centuries ago, that if you must speak loudly to be heard, then you've already lost the argument. The Whispers honor that teaching."

The Labyrinth of Reflection follows. Each member who needs to be tested undertakes a solo journey through tunnels beneath Omoyano. The routes vary by person and need. Some complete the maze in

hours. Some take days. What they encounter in darkness stays private. Everyone emerges changed.

What makes the Labyrinth remarkable is not simply the underground passages themselves; it is what one encounters in them. The tunnels were carved with the same precision as the Tower's stonework, using techniques that predate any current Saskan capability. Some chambers contain questions written on walls in scripts that mix strange notation with proto-Eibar. Some contain objects, fragments of technology, preserved specimens, artifacts that shouldn't exist, positioned to provoke specific contemplation.

The Labyrinth is a teaching tool. Its designer or designers understood that certain knowledge transfers best through direct confrontation with mystery rather than explanation. It has been guiding members for many centuries, adjusting what those exploring it encounter based on what they need to learn.

The Trials of the Sacred Scale provide the Conclave's objective core. This involves six weeks of public demonstrations where members prove their capabilities. But even here, peculiarity intrudes. The Trials test not only skill but capacity to maintain skill under conditions that shouldn't be physically possible.

The Terpinol report describes watching a Beqawar ranger demonstrate silent movement across a floor deliberately constructed to amplify sound, with boards that should have creaked remaining utterly quiet under weight that should have betrayed presence. A member of the Table of Isara solved a mathematical proof while maintaining three conversations in three languages simultaneously, cognitive load that should have made accurate calculation impossible. A student from the Lyra taught a complex concept to audiences of different ages and expertise levels, adjusting approach in real-time with precision that suggested either supernatural empathy or very sophisticated training in pedagogical theory.

The recorded performances exceeded normal hum and sint capabilities by margins that raised some interesting -- and uncomfortable -- questions about what, exactly, the Empafarasi teach their members and for what purpose.

The Weaving of Visions provides counterbalance. The meditation sessions are facilitated by the Table of Seraf and they produce accounts of possible futures, symbolic narratives, and insights which inform strategic planning without depending purely on logical analysis. The visions are recorded and preserved. Some have proven eerily accurate. Three turns ago, during the Weaving, seven separate members from different Tables independently described the same vision: a figure that appeared human but moved wrongly, spoke correctly but felt hollow, and gradually became more real through a relationship with someone who refused to treat it as thing.

At the time, the vision made no sense. Members debated its meaning without resolution. The accounts were archived as interesting but ambiguous. Two turns later, the first detailed intelligence reports began arriving about large-scale Jaxen infiltration in Barból. The Empafarasi who need to know know that the Jaxen are Maken constructs designed to pass as human. The old visions suddenly acquired urgent relevance. The House restructured its counter-intelligence approaches based partly on insights from meditations that predated the threat's recognition.

How? The Terpin scholar wanted rational explanation. Hypotheses included pattern recognition, subconscious or dream-level processing of subtle indicators, and a theory about collective intelligence emerging from group meditation. But re-read the accounts of those vision records and you might begin to recognize a different pattern. Sometimes they describe things that shouldn't be known yet. And sometimes the handwriting in the margins, the notations analyzing what each vision might mean, matches that odd script found in the High Table chamber and on some of the sensitive documents in the vaults.

Could it be that someone guides the Weaving? Someone with experience spanning centuries, with knowledge of threats that haven't fully manifested, with understanding of how human consciousness works at levels that suggest they've studied it from angles we can't quite achieve.

The Ceremony of Renovation concludes each Conclave. A Council of Elders announces the new Table rankings and each Table proclaims

how its seats will be organized and Names are announced. The High Tables rise or fall based on performance. Members receive acknowledgment or demotion.

The Omoyan Shinilcha attends the Ceremony of Renovation but does not speak. Khar-Mael's presence alone signifies approval. The figure in sealed armor sits among the gathered Tables of the House, radiating attention that feels simultaneously distant and intensely focused, and then departs once the ceremony concludes.

No words. No explanations. Just a presence that indicates the work continues. You have done well. We will proceed.

After forty turns studying this system, the Terpinol scholar reached the conclusion that the Conclave isn't, in fact, primarily about organizational efficiency. It's about maintaining the connection between an institution of sentient beings, mostly hum, who live for decades and a being who has lived for untold centuries, teaching each generation anew that the work transcends their individual lifetimes and requires humility about their temporary place in patterns that began long before them and will continue after.

The Names

Every member who completes initial training receives a Name. The word is capitalized deliberately, to distinction this title from names given at birth. The process involves the whole Table to which they have sought or to whom they naturally have an affiliation. Members propose options. They debate appropriateness. They select something that feels right in a way that resists systematic explanation.

The Named One carries that identity within the House. A hum born Daven becomes Deepstone after demonstrating patience in geological survey work that required decades of observation. A worker named Saril becomes Bridgeward after mastering the art of finding language that connects hostile perspectives. The birth names persist for family use or external travel, but within High Weir, the Name takes precedence.

This creates a linguistic environment that sounds strange to outsiders. Folks called Threshold, Cascade, Clarity, Ember, Stillwind, Risingdawn work alongside each other in communal halls. It sounds pretentious until you experience what it does. I reminds everyone, constantly, that their identity within the House derives from what they've accomplished and what they contribute, not from their brood or what they were called prior to finding their true work.

Those occupying the highest seats of the Tower Tables carry both personal Names and positional titles. Commander Tavren Ironwatch. Scholar Seraphine Bridgeword. The dual identity reinforces that position serves the work, not ego.

But the Omoyan Shinilcha Khar-Mael carries only that title. No family affiliation appears in any contract. No one is even entirely sure what it means, if anything. It does not have a semantic root in any Saskan language.

Ask about this, and you receive careful non-answers:

"The Omoyan's Name is the work itself."

"What matters is the vigil, not the one who keeps it."

"Some questions answer themselves through observation rather than asking."

Here's what the permitted observations have revealed. In the oldest House archives, in contracts written during the early turns after the arrival, the title appears immediately. No transition from personal name to title. No record of when someone became the Omoyan Shinilcha Khar-Mael. The title simply exists from the beginning, as if it had always existed, as if the person and the position were never separable. It is as if the one holding that seat never had another identity to remember, or chose not to remember it, or lived so long in that role that whatever they were before no longer matters.

The Eleven Empty Chairs

Here is where every analysis ultimately arrives, where every theory

constructed ultimately tends to fail. The High Table chamber at the Mistral Tower's apex contains twelve chairs carved from dark stone threaded with metallic veins. Eleven stand empty. One shows the polish of use across centuries.

For probably two thousand turns, or since the Tower's construction, this arrangement appears to have persisted unchanged. The empty chairs gather no dust; someone maintains them. They show no damage; someone cares for them. They remain precisely positioned around the circular table; someone adjusts them back to exact placement if they're ever moved. But no one sits in them. Ever. Not during Conclave ceremonies. Not during Table meetings. Not even when Khar-Mael hosts rare audiences with external dignitaries or coordinates with high-ranking Names.

The chairs simply stand empty, waiting for occupants who have never arrived or who aren't here yet or who perhaps existed once and departed, leaving only furniture to mark their absence. The trusted Terpinol scholar was permitted to interview every member of the House who has entered the High Table chamber during the time of his studies. The accounts vary slightly, but certain elements remained consistent.

The room feels larger than its eighteen-meter diameter should allow. The acoustic properties defy normal physics. Whispers carry across the entire space while normal speech somehow dampens. The dome's interior surface might be metal rather than stone, possibly reflective, possibly designed to manipulate sound in ways architecture shouldn't achieve alone. And the chairs. Always the chairs. Positioned with exactness that suggests ritual significance, carved from a strange material, showing design coherence with the table itself, as if the entire assemblage were created as a single work then separated into components.

Ariadne of Isara, who has been called to the chamber often, shared this observation: "The chairs show different wear patterns. The one Khar-Mael sits in, obviously, is polished smooth by use. But three others show slight wear. Not from sitting, but from hands resting on the arms, as if someone stood behind those seats frequently, leaning on them while looking at something on the table's surface. The other

eight show no wear at all. They might have been placed there yesterday."

Three chairs touched frequently. Eight never touched. One used constantly. Twelve total. Symbolic? Functional? Aspirational? No one knows. And if they do know, they're not telling.

But here's what makes the mystery acute. Sometimes, very occasionally, a member of the highest Tables is summoned to the High Table chamber for consultation. They climb the spiral staircase. Four hundred steps, roughly fifteen minutes for someone unaccustomed to the altitude. They arrive slightly hypoxic, breath quick, legs heavy. And Khar-Mael is waiting, seated in the one used chair, armored form absolutely still, and the summoned member takes position standing, never sitting, near one of the empty chairs while discussing whatever crisis or question prompted the summons.

Tavren Ironwatch, summoned more than any other current member, described his first experience: "I stood beside one of the empty chairs on the northern side of the table. The Omoyan asked my assessment of a Maken probe pattern. I gave my analysis. The Omoyan listened, then asked a follow-up question that revealed I'd missed a crucial connection. We discussed it further. At one point, I started to sit in the empty chair. It seemed natural, I was exhausted from the climb and I had recently returned from a long patrol. The Omoyan made a small gesture. Not forbidding, exactly. More like... a reminder. That seat wasn't for me. Not yet. Maybe not ever. But it was there for a reason."

When the scholar pressed about what that reason might be, it is written that Tavren's expression turned distant. "The Omoyan told me, once, that the House was built to outlast any individual's lifetime. That continuity required more than one person could provide, even one who lived far longer than normal measure. That the work would eventually require... distribution across multiple bearers. And then the Omoyan Shinilcha said something I didn't fully understand: 'The chairs wait for those who can carry what one being shouldn't have to carry alone.'"

The Paradox

So we return to the question: How do you build an institution to outlast a being who has already outlasted everything? The answer appears to be that you build a system so carefully balanced that it functions with or without central authority, so adaptable that it can survive leadership transition, so distributed that no single point of failure can collapse the whole structure. And then you position yourself at the center anyway, because you have knowledge that can't be transferred, because you understand threats that emerged before anyone else was born, because you've been doing this work so long that removing yourself would create vacuum that nothing else could fill.

This is the paradox at the heart of the House of Empafarasi. It is a deeply meritocratic system crowned by an unexamined authority. An organization built for distributed leadership centered on a being who occupies singular position. An institution designed to outlast individual lifespans sustained by someone who has, apparently, transcended normal lifespan limitations many times over.

Younger members occasionally question this arrangement. Arguments emerge. If merit determines position for everyone else, why not for the High Table? If evaluation matters for all other seats, why does the Omoyan face no trial? The response from senior members stays consistent: "The Omoyan's work justifies the exception. Until someone demonstrates equivalent capability in that work, the question remains academic."

Fair enough. But it avoids the deeper question: What happens when that work finally concludes? What happens to an organization built around a being who has shaped it for centuries when that being is finally no longer necessary? Do the empty chairs fill then? Does the High Table become what the rest of the structure already is: a meritocratic council where position derives from capability rather than simply from having stood watch for longer than anyone can calculate? Or is the House, ultimately, not designed to outlast Khar-Mael but to become the distributed form of whatever Khar-Mael is, to transform one being's impossible vigil into institutional permanence, spreading the burden across enough people that it becomes bearable?

The Terpinol scholar spent forty turns studying this question, interviewed hundreds of House members, examined every contract and every founding document that was made available, and studied every piece of evidence about how this organization came to be and how it persists. And the lengthy report sitting in the Terpinol Library still doesn't provide an answer.

The House of Empafarasi works. It adapts. It survives transition, resists corruption, maintains purpose across generations. It functions with precision that exceeds what human organizations normally achieve. And at its heart sits someone, or something, that has been there since before the beginning, shaping the structure, guiding the Conclave, maintaining standards that shouldn't be maintainable across time.

The eleven empty chairs wait. The work continues. And somewhere in High Weir, in the deep hours before dawn when even the diligent sleep, Khar-Mael sits at the High Table and speaks names aloud in the darkness, the names of people who died centuries ago, names of those who carry the work now, names that preserve memory across duration that should erase everything.

The walls don't answer. The empty chairs remain silent. But the names are spoken anyway, because someone refuses to let time win completely.

Where Altitude Becomes Argument

The climb takes four hours in summer, eight in winter. Seventeen switchbacks ascending 800 vertical meters of fitted stone so precisely cut that gaps between blocks measure less than two millimeters. Every hundred meters, a rest platform. Every platform, access to water flowing from channels that never freeze completely even in deep winter.

By the time you reach Omoyano's outer terraces, your lungs are

burning in air that feels too thin to sustain thought, and you've had time to contemplate why anyone would build here. At 4,200 meters elevation, this is the highest permanent settlement in Saskantanon. The cold alone should make it uninhabitable. The logistics of supply should make it unsustainable. The sheer difficulty of getting here should have prevented establishment.

Yet it persists. For hundreds and hundreds of turns. Three thousand residents at any given time. Not merely surviving but functioning with precision that suggests this elevation, this exposure, this impossible altitude serves a purpose that overrides every practical objection.

The first time you see the terraces descending the southeastern face of Mount Hgarra like architectural echoes of the central spire and the Mistral Tower spiraling upward from the summit plaza you understand that this isn't a settlement that evolved organically. This is an installation built according to plan that predated the settlers who would eventually inhabit it.

The question that haunts every analysis is, what makes this location so critical that someone chose to place their primary observation post higher than any other human habitation, at the literal roof of the known world? The answer, once you consider again after climbing up there, is as simple as it is obvious. At Omoyano, you can see everything. And perhaps more importantly, everything can see you.

Exposure as Statement

The trail to Omoyano offers no cover within bow range. This is deliberate. First-time visitors report profound discomfort at the visibility, the sense of being observed by watchers they cannot see. They are correct to feel watched. They are being observed, from multiple vantage points, by rangers who can kill at 80 meters with arrows that never miss because the shooters have trained at this altitude since childhood. But the exposure serves deeper purpose than defense. It announces that if you come here, you come without deception. We will see you long before you arrive, and by the time you reach our terraces, we will know whether you're permitted to

proceed.

A trusted scholar from Terpinol was granted access during his second decade of research, after many turns of formal petitions and careful cultivation of relationships with junior members of Vyan had passed. The summons came without warning: "The House has reviewed your scholarship. You may ascend. Send word when you're prepared to make the journey."

He climbed in late spring, when snowmelt had turned the trail to mud and the afternoon sun provided brief warmth between dawn cold and evening freeze. Every rest platform felt necessary, not luxury but requirement, the body demanding pause to process altitude that keeps most visitors slightly hypoxic for their entire stay.

At the final switchback, a Beqawar ranger stood waiting. Dark armor, compound bow, face covered by fabric that revealed eyes that assessed without hostility but without warmth either. The ranger said nothing. Made a small gesture toward the terrace above. Watched as the scholar completed the final ascent. When the visitor from Terpinol turned back once, at the top, to have a word with his guide, the ranger had vanished. No footfall, no sound of departure. Just absence where presence had been moments before.

Welcome to High Weir, where the mountain ghosts are very much corporeal and have been watching the approach trails for far longer than your grandfather's grandfather's grandfather's grandfather drew breath.

Architecture as Mission Profile

Omoyano descends in nine distinct terraces, each corresponding to one of the Tables resident in the Tower. This isn't decorative symbolism. It's organizational logic made visible. The physical space is the hierarchy. You can see, literally, where each function sits in relation to others. What makes it remarkable is that the terraces don't feel like separate domains. Water flows between them. Staircases connect them at multiple points. Gardens on lower levels supply herbs for upper-level workshops. The structure functions as integrated

system, not layered fortress.

This suggests design philosophy. Hierarchy exists to organize function, not to separate people. Position matters, but position serves the work, and the work requires everyone.

The First Terrace contains only the Tower's base and a circular plaza fifty meters across. No permanent structures. No habitation. Just open space for gatherings that require the entire House on rare occasions, perhaps twice per turn, when everyone who can walk climbs to the summit and stands together before ascending further to the Tower proper.

The Terpinol guest witnessed this once, during a memorial ceremony for Roderick of the Dorn, who died in office at age seventy-three after forty turns of service. Three thousand people filled the plaza at dawn. No speeches. No formal program. Just presence. Everyone stood together in silence as first light touched the eastern valleys, as the Tower began its low harmonic with morning winds, as the collective understanding settled that one who carried the work had passed and others would continue.

After ten minutes, the crowd dispersed. Work resumed. Life continued. But something in that collective silence communicated more effectively than any eulogy could have that we stand together. The work matters more than any individual. We remember those who served and we proceed.

The terraces below show the same functional precision. Alzara's military infrastructure built for efficiency not display. Vyan's spaces designed for conversation and negotiation. Isara's chaotic-looking laboratories that actually maintain meticulous organization. Dorn's relentlessly practical administration chambers where the unglamorous work of feeding 3,400 people at altitude occurs in ledgers and logistics.

Every terrace includes gardens. This isn't an aesthetic choice, it's a survival requirement. At this elevation, supply lines become precarious. Self-sufficiency matters. So every available space that can support growth does so, carefully managed, precisely tended, producing enough supplementary food that Omoyano could,

theoretically, survive complete isolation for several months. It is as if whoever designed this place anticipated scenarios where outside support might fail. As if the settlement needed capability to sustain itself through periods when connecting to the broader world became impossible or unwise.

The feeling grows stronger the longer you stay. This isn't simply a mountain town. It's a station. Built for long-term habitation by people who understand their work might require isolation, who have prepared for contingencies that hopefully will never occur, who maintain readiness for situations that most of Saskantinnon has forgotten could happen.

The Mistral Tower

Seventy-three meters of vertical height. Spiral form making one complete rotation from base to crown. Dark stone showing metallic veining that catches light in ways ordinary rock doesn't. Apertures positioned according to the helical pattern, allowing air flow that creates acoustic resonance when the mistral blows.

Described like this, it sounds like architecture. Ambitious architecture, certainly, but still recognizable as a building designed by people who understood stonework and engineering. Then you experience it during strong mistral winds and realize the Tower is something else, something more, entirely.

The harmonic it produces fluctuates between 40 and 60 Hz depending on wind speed and direction. This isn't random variation. The Tower is responding to atmospheric conditions, creating tones that carry information about weather patterns hours before conventional signs appear. The Empafarasi can distinguish seventeen different mistral types by listening to the Tower's song, each indicating specific atmospheric conditions.

There's more. The harmonic can be felt in the chest, in the bones, in spaces behind thought where normal sensation doesn't reach. Some have claimed the frequencies match planetary resonance patterns. Others believe they serve communication purposes, carrying signals

across distances where visual methods fail. During three weeks at Omoyano during a particularly active mistral season, the Terpinol sage who devoted his career to studying the Empafarasi learned to distinguish five or six basic wind types by their sound. The locals could identify all seventeen and were making predictions about weather three days out based on subtleties the Terpinol expert couldn't perceive.

On the eighth day, he asked Ariadne of the Isara, who has studied the Tower's acoustic properties more extensively than anyone except possibly the Omoyan, what exactly the Tower was designed to do. She considered the question for a long moment, then said, "It was designed to remain in contact. With what, we're not entirely certain. With all of Gavor-Havorra possibly. The resonance patterns suggest deep geological harmonics. With atmospheric conditions, obviously. With... other things. Things that might need to know that this location remains active, remains inhabited, remains maintained by beings who understand what the Tower represents, even if we can't articulate all its functions."

"Are you saying the Tower is a beacon?", she was asked.

"I'm saying the Tower announces presence to something that might be listening."

The conversation ended there. But the scholar wrote about the idea for a full year after returning to the Academy, exploring possibilities. If the Tower is beacon, if it announces presence to listeners unknown, then Omoyano isn't simply a settlement at a high altitude. It's a relay station. Maintained for centuries. Still broadcasting. Still watched over by whoever occupies the High Table and understands what must not be allowed to go silent.

The High Table Chamber

Four hundred steps up the spiral staircase. Fifteen minutes for someone moving steadily. Longer if you pause for breath, which you will. The altitude and exertion combine to create mild hypoxia that some describe as clarity and others as lightheadedness. By the time

you reach the uppermost chamber, you're not entirely yourself. The thin air has made thought feel both sharp and distant. Your legs are heavy. Your heart pounds harder than it should. And you enter a space that defies comfortable explanation.

It is eighteen meters across. Domed ceiling rising another six meters at the peak. Six windows are positioned to provide views in all cardinal directions plus intermediate points. On clear days visibility extends over 200 kilometers. You can see the upper reaches of the Pavan River valley, the southern approaches to high Krunkinotto ranges, and the western edge of known geography if atmospheric conditions align perfectly.

The circular table occupies the chamber's center. Four meters in diameter. Carved from single piece of dark stone threaded with metallic veins forming patterns that suggest written language, mathematical notation, or possibly pure abstraction. Twelve chairs surround it, each carved from the same material as the table itself. Eleven of the chairs stand empty. One shows the polish of centuries of use.

The Terpinol scholar was permitted to enter this chamber exactly once, during his eighteenth turn of research, after Ariadne argued successfully that his scholarship merited direct observation of the space he'd been writing about secondhand. The Omoyan was not present. The scholar had perhaps ten minutes before the escort who brought him in politely indicated time had expired. His notes indicate that the table's surface shows markings that definitely constitute notation of some kind. Not decorative engraving, functional symbols arranged in what might be equations or maps or linguistic structures. Some markings align with notation systems documented in fragmentary pre-Catastrophe texts. Others don't match anything in the known scholarly records at Terpinol, Byenung or Ingar.

He walked around the table, examining each of the chairs. The one showing use, with arms worn smooth, seat polished by contact, sits on the eastern side, positioned to face west. Three others show subtle wear on the arms, as if someone stood behind them frequently, hands resting there while examining something on the table's surface. Eight show no wear at all.

The dome's interior surface is smooth and dark. Possibly metal. Sound carries clearly across the entire chamber despite the space's size. When speaking at normal volume, the sound somehow dampens, flattens, as if the acoustic properties were constructed to make quiet speech more effective than loud.

And the feeling. The scholar noted that chamber feels inhabited even when empty. Not haunted. Nothing threatening or supernatural. But occupied. As if a presence persists in the space independent of whether anyone currently sits there. As if the work that occurs at that table has soaked into the stone itself, and become part of the chamber's fundamental nature.

The escort spoke to the scholar only once during his visit. As they prepared to descend, he said: "You'll write about this room now, having seen it. That's fine. That's why you were granted access. But understand that what you've seen is the space where decisions are made. Not the decisions themselves. Not the knowledge that informs them. Just the room where someone sits, alone among those empty chairs, and chooses how the work continues."

The scholar spent five turns after that visit pondering every detail. The markings on the table suggest planning that spans timescales beyond hum and sint lifetime: centuries of accumulated notes, adjustments, recalibrations as circumstances change. The wear patterns on three chairs suggest the work hasn't always been solitary. Perhaps others sat there once, or will again, or somehow occupy those positions in ways we can't observe.

The eleven empty chairs haunted him most. Are they memorials? Markers of succession? Future positions waiting to be filled? Symbolic representations of distributed function that currently concentrates in one being? If anyone knows for sure, they're not telling. But the chamber was obviously designed for twelve and currently it holds one. And that one has been sufficient for longer than institutional memory can track.

Hidden in Plain Sight

The stone throughout Omoyano contains metallic inclusions showing iron, nickel, and trace elements in ratios that don't match known Gavoran ore formations. Analysis by Isara members has documented this conclusively. The material suggests either unusual geological processes or, as some have quietly speculated, stone that incorporates fragments of materials not originating on Gavor-Havorra.

The precision of stonecutting exceeds capabilities demonstrated elsewhere in Saskantion by margins that raise uncomfortable questions. Blocks fit with gaps measuring less than one millimeter. No mortar. No visible tool marks. Just perfect joinery that has survived centuries of thermal cycling with minimal displacement.

The Empafarasi guard these techniques carefully. When their favorite visiting scholar asked how the stones were cut, Ariadne smiled and said: "With great patience and very sharp tools." When he pressed for technical details, she added: "The methods were developed over generations of practice. We teach them to selected apprentices who swear not to discuss specific procedures. This isn't about maintaining monopoly. It's about maintaining standards. The precision requires discipline that can't be rushed, understanding that can't be explained, only demonstrated through long apprenticeship."

Fair enough, the scholar wrote, but the tools glimpsed in restricted workshops didn't look like anything used elsewhere in the Saskan Lands. The metalwork shows alloying that shouldn't be achievable with conventional smelting. The cutting edges maintain sharpness through use that should dull any normal blade.

Technology is present here. Not obvious. Not mechanical in the sense of moving parts or visible machinery. But integrated into materials and methods in ways that extend human capability by margins that become apparent only through careful observation. The lamps, for instance. They burn with unusual steadiness, consuming fuel slowly, producing minimal smoke. Members of the House maintain them but discuss their construction only in vague terms about careful filtering and optimized wick design. The scholar compared them to all known styles of lamps throughout Saskantion, and came to the conclusion that nothing else performs like Empafarasi lights.

Then there are the water channels that flow against apparent gradient

for short distances. And the doors that close themselves slowly after opening, as if on dampened hinges that contain no visible mechanism. The acoustic properties in certain chambers that defy architectural explanation. Someone built this place who had access to materials and techniques that predate the migration. Someone created infrastructure designed to last centuries with minimal maintenance, and anticipated that isolated installation at impossible altitude would need self-sufficiency in everything from water management to illumination.

Someone has been here since the beginning, maintaining standards, training each generation in methods that can't be fully explained because they derive from knowledge that mustn't be spoken aloud.

The Rhythm of Long Purpose

Omoyano wakes before dawn. The light from the High Table first pierces the darkness, then the entire town begins to move. At 4,200 meters, sunrise comes early and cold. First light finds people already moving, beginning work that won't pause until darkness returns. Communal meals serve functional purpose beyond nutrition. They maintain social bonds. They ensure everyone eats sufficiently for altitude demands. They create moments where information flows informally like news spreading, problems identified, coordination occurring without formal meetings.

Work fills the day according to Table affiliation, but the boundaries blur. A member of Dorn might consult with Isara about supply chain improvements. A Beqawar between rotations might help Lyra teach tracking skills to students. The structure exists to organize function, not to separate people into silos.

Evening meals last longer, with more social interaction. This is when the House maintains itself as a whole community rather than just an organization made up of parts. Music occurs naturally. Someone produces an instrument, others join, songs emerge that carry generations of accumulated tradition.

Night brings watch rotations. Someone always stays alert. The mountains harbor plenty of threats, and altitude makes complacency

fatal. But more than security concerns, the watches maintain the principle that the work never ceases. Someone must always be paying attention, because situations that require response don't respect rest cycles.

The Terpinol scholar spent enough time at Omoyano to recognize patterns. His volumes make for fascinating reading. The Empafarasi settlement functions with a precision that exceeds what purely hum organization typically achieves. Only the miners' collective of Eelan comes anywhere close to it. Problems get identified early. Solutions emerge through informal consensus before formal intervention becomes necessary. Resource allocation occurs with minimal waste.

This isn't perfect harmony, however. Disputes do arise, personalities clash, folks make mistakes. But the system has built-in correction mechanisms that function at scales suggesting long institutional experience with how hum organizations fail and how to prevent those failures. It feels less like a town and more like a crew. Everyone understands their role. Everyone knows their mission. Everyone accepts that individual preferences subordinate to collective function because the work, whatever exactly the work is, matters more than personal comfort.

It is similar to the feeling on a long-range sea voyage. The way of life in a habitation designed for long duration by folks who understand that comfort is secondary to mission completion, that every individual role matters for survival of the whole, and that maintaining standards isn't optional when you're this far from support systems.

The View from the Tower

From the High Table chamber, on clear days, you can see practically everything that matters in the western Saskan Lands. The northern river valleys descending toward Liganalupán, Eelan and Bored. The approaches to the high Krunkinotto where containment must be maintained. The southern territories where settlements of many kinds are growing. The western frontier where threats emerge from regions that the Beqawar patrol but don't discuss publicly.

This isn't scenic vista. It's tactical overview. Someone sitting at that table can assess the entire defensive perimeter visually, can watch weather patterns develop, can observe movement across distances that make detailed identification impossible but allow detection of general activity. For someone maintaining vigil over threats that span this geography, for someone who needs to maintain awareness of everything occurring across thousands of square kilometers, for someone whose primary function is watching, this location is optimal. It's also isolated. Deliberately, necessarily isolated. At 4,200 meters, casual visitors are few. Supply is difficult. Communication requires effort. The elevation creates separation from the world below, creates space for contemplation without constant interruption, creates environment where someone could maintain focus across timeframes that would be impossible in more accessible locations.

Sitting in that chamber once, briefly, while the Omoyan was absent, the Terpinol scholar understood that it is not a throne room. It is an observation post. Someone sits here not because the height impresses but because the height provides necessary perspective. Someone maintains a post here not for glory but because the work requires someone to watch, constantly, across centuries, until the threats finally diminish or transform or are replaced by whatever comes next.

The eleven empty chairs suggest that this vigil wasn't always meant to be solitary. Perhaps others sat here once. Perhaps others will again. Perhaps the work that currently concentrates in one being will eventually be distributed across many, and the chamber will fill with the council it was apparently designed to hold.

But for now, for centuries past, for as long as institutional memory can track, it was one figure. One position. One being in sealed armor sitting among those empty chairs and maintaining a watch that must never cease.

The Mistral Tower stands. The wind blows through its spiral architecture. The settlement attached to it maintains the rhythms of long purpose. At the apex, someone who has been here since before the beginning continues work that most folks don't know exists, watching threats that most prefer to forget, maintaining standards that ensure the work will continue even after the watcher finally rests, if

that day ever comes, if rest is even possible after centuries of vigilance, if someone who has become the work itself can ever distinguish between ending the vigil and simply ceasing to exist.

These are questions that the Terpinol scholar could not answer. But they haunted him as he write about Omoyano, this impossible settlement at an impossible altitude, maintained by impossible dedication, serving a purpose that exceeded his capacity to document it.

Their ship sails on through the centuries. The Empafarasi crew maintains their stations. The mission continues. And at the helm, visible to all but known by none, someone steers toward destinations that only they can see.

Practicing Silence

They rode into Ríkila at dawn. Sixty rangers on dark mounts, arriving from five approach vectors simultaneously, positioning themselves between warring factions before most of the town realized armed strangers had appeared. They enforced cessation of violence through presence alone, remained twelve days while negotiators worked, then departed as suddenly as they came, leaving only a small rotation to patrol the gate separating the warring sides.

Five Beqawar were injured. None killed. Fewer than twenty deaths among the combatants they confronted, mostly among those who tested whether the mountain ghosts would actually fight. The ghosts fought and the testing quickly stopped. Neither Tagabant nor rebel had ever seen anything like it.

Twenty years later, people throughout the Saskan Lands still argue about what the Ríkila intervention means. What gave the Empafarasi authority to intervene in distant conflicts? What intelligence network allowed such precise timing in a place so far away from their base in the far western mountains? What capabilities remain hidden if sixty

rangers could dominate a town where hundreds of fighters had reached a bloody stalemate after months of urban fighting?

The Beqawar themselves discuss it rarely, and when they do, with characteristic understatement. One ranger interviewed by B'arqo, one who had been part of the Ríkila deployment, described it thus: "We were asked to prevent massacre. We prevented it. The operation succeeded. We returned to our actual work."

"Which is?"

"Patrol. Observation. Maintenance of watch posts. The usual."

The usual. As if riding the highest, coldest, most dangerous patrol routes in Saskantinon while watching for threats that most people don't believe exist constitutes normal employment. This is the essential character of the Beqawar. They have become legend while considering themselves merely competent practitioners of necessary craft. The legend serves purposes. The craft is what actually matters.

What the Name Reveals

Beqawar means guardians of hum settlements" in a rare Liganalupán dialect of Eibar. It sounds somewhat similar to and has the same root as the Varkaar term for their elite units, the Báhkar. Both terms date from the great migration, when rangers and guides protected refugee columns from threats emerging from wilderness. Two millennia later the migration routes are long gone, the refugees have become large settled populations scattered across six major sub-regions, and the threats have transformed from opportunistic predators to something far more organized and far more dangerous.

But the essential function persists: protection. Watch. Maintaining vigil over borders that most people don't know need guarding.

Other cultures have given them different names, each revealing something about perception:

The Kahila call them mounted ghosts for their capacity to appear where not expected. The Kahila, who value spontaneous individual

prowess, find the Beqawar's disciplined patience profoundly unsettling.

The Eelani, who probably know the Beqawar better than anyone, call them silent watchers, in a recognition of skill from folks who understand mountain craft quite well themselves. The Eelani rangers occasionally encounter Beqawar patrols in border regions. They've learned not to be surprised when the Empafarasi soldiers appear without sound where no approach should have been possible.

Fatunik and Bordali folk tend to call them mountain shadows, often with an uneasy undertone. To Dominion scribes, the Beqawar represent an organized martial force that operates outside legitimate authority.

Among themselves, they use Beqawar. When asked about the various appellations, one veteran told the popular bard and publicist, "Folks can call us whatever they like. Our mounts know we're real. The mountains know we're here. That's sufficient."

Numbers

It appears that there are approximately 340 active Beqawar at any given time, roughly ten percent of the total population of the House of the Empafarasi. This ratio has remained stable for at least a century, suggesting either deliberate organizational maintenance or natural limits on how many people can sustain the physical and psychological demands of ranger service. The number feels small until you consider the territory they cover: 15,000 square kilometers of mountain terrain, from patrol routes through High Weir's settled zones to watch posts facing the Krunkinotto, to reconnaissance missions that extend into regions the House doesn't publicly claim. At which point it feels even smaller.

The organization divides into kelani, which are blade-groups of seven to nine rangers, each responsible for defined sectors. The teams operate with significant autonomy, coordinating through kelani-mar (blade-leaders) who maintain positions at key stations and serve as communication nodes. This distributed structure creates resilience. No

single point of failure can collapse the system. If one team encounters situations beyond their capacity, nearby teams respond. If a sector becomes untenable, patrols reroute. The network adapts rather than breaking.

The system has functioned this way for centuries with minimal modification to core structure. The original organizational design has proven sufficiently robust that it requires only tactical adjustments, not strategic reimagining. Someone with extensive experience watching human organizations fail across time designed this system. Someone who understood that rigid hierarchy creates brittleness while pure autonomy creates chaos, and who found the balance point between those extremes. Someone who has been refining the approach across centuries, making small adjustments as threats evolve but maintaining fundamental architecture that has proven sound. The Beqawar know who that someone is. They report ultimately to the High Table, though operational independence remains high. When situations require strategic guidance, when threat patterns shift, when intervention beyond the western mountains becomes necessary, when questions arise about adapting doctrine to new circumstances, they consult with Tavren Ironwatch of the Alzara Table, who consults with Khar-Mael.

Occasionally, very rarely, a ranger receives summons to the High Table itself for consultation that cannot occur through intermediaries. Those who have made that climb speak of it carefully, if they speak of it at all.

Who Can Endure

Becoming Beqawar begins young, around age ten for those who show aptitude. They are all hum. There are no sints in Omoyan. And not everyone suited to mountain life is suited for ranger work. The order needs people who can maintain alertness through long periods of nothing happening, who can operate for days with minimal social contact, who can execute sudden violence after weeks of peaceful patrol. The training intensifies gradually. Physical capacity first, then endurance at altitude, balance on difficult terrain, tolerance for cold

that makes breathing visible. And skills: navigation, tracking, understanding ecology and resources of different zones, moving through landscape without leaving obvious trace.

Combat training starts around age fifteen, but the distinctive Beqawar specialization, fighting in complete silence, develops slowly across years of practice. This is the part that generates legends. This is what makes them appear supernatural to those who haven't watched the thousands of hours of training required to move without sound, to detect movement through vibration, to navigate by reflected sound in darkness. It's not supernatural. It's refined technique practiced until it becomes automatic. But the result, to unprepared observers, can seem like magic.

A Threshold Patrol serves as the final evaluation. It is a solo journey covering roughly 150 kilometers over ten to twelve days through terrain where Maken activity has been detected within the past year. Minimal supplies. No marked trails. Complete the route on schedule while avoiding detection by any hostiles in the area. Approximately seventy percent succeed on first attempt. Those who fail often do so not from incompetence but from recognition that the life of a Beqawar doesn't fit their nature. Many become valuable House members in other capacities. No stigma attaches to stepping back from training.

Those who succeed receive their designation in ceremony at the Tower's base when they receive their full kit: weapons, armor, tools that show technological sophistication beyond standard Saskan craftsmanship. And then they join a kelani for first operational rotation.

One Beqawar described the moment of receiving full status: "They handed me the bow. The arrows. The blade. After the full prostration, Tavren spoke to me directly briefly about the work, about maintaining watch, protecting what must be protected, honoring those who carried the burden before us. Then he said something I didn't fully understand at the time: 'The Omoyan has maintained this vigil since before any of us drew first breath. We are the distribution of that vigil across many hands. We carry together what one being should never carry alone.'"

Equipment

The compound bow measures 1.3 meters unstrung, constructed from laminated materials that include wood, horn, and something with metallic properties that provides tension without brittleness. Draw weight ranges from 35 to 50 kilograms, which is sufficient to drive arrows through armor at 80 meters. The arrows use fletching that doesn't exist elsewhere in Saskan, synthetic vanes providing stable flight without organic materials. The construction technique is carefully guarded. When B'arqo asked how they're made, the response was: "With patience and proper materials."

"What materials?"

A slight smile. "Proper ones."

The armor represents the most visible technological divergence from standard Saskan equipment. Overlapping plates of dark material, not quite metal, not quite composite, that provide protection while remaining lighter than equivalent metal armor would weigh. Total system weight is approximately 12 kilograms for full torso coverage. In certain light conditions, the plates seem to absorb rather than reflect illumination, making armored rangers appear as dark shapes even in daylight. Whether this represents deliberate design or material side effect remains unclear.

The Terpinol scholar of the Empafarasi once asked Ariadne of Isara about the armor's composition. She considered the question, then said: "The materials have properties we don't fully understand. We can replicate the manufacturing process and we teach it to selected apprentices, but we're following procedures developed long ago by someone with more sophisticated materials knowledge than current Saskan scholarship has recovered. We maintain the techniques without completely understanding the principles."

"Developed by whom?"

"By whoever established the original forge-workshops beneath Omoyano. The same hands that built the Tower, probably. The same mind that understood we'd need equipment capable of functioning reliably in extreme conditions against adversaries that process

information faster than human thought."

Someone who understood what the rangers would face built equipment adequate to that challenge. Someone with access to pre-Catastrophe materials and methods created weapons and armor that exceed current capabilities by margins just large enough to matter in combat against mechanical opponents. Someone who has been equipping the Beqawar for centuries, maintaining forge-techniques across generations, ensuring each fighter receives tools that might save their life when facing enemies that calculate optimal responses faster than humans can react.

Daily Life

A typical patrol rotation lasts thirty-six days: twenty-eight in the field, eight in Omoyano for rest and equipment maintenance. The field days follow rhythms that vary little season to season, year to year.

Morning begins before dawn. Movement to raise core temperature and the full prostration ritual that seems so startling when first observed. Breakfast that's functional rather than pleasurable. Equipment inspection occurs daily: weapons, armor, tools, everything checked for damage or moisture. Mount preparation is done with similar care. Patrol departure with first sufficient light. The kelani moves in formation appropriate to terrain and tactical situation. Conversation stays minimal. The day's travel covers anywhere from fifteen to forty kilometers depending on mission requirements.

And then observation. Watching for signs. Tracks. Disturbed vegetation. Unusual arrangements. Scent on wind. Listening to ambient sound, noting deviations from expected patterns. Stopping at overlook points to scan distant terrain through magnification devices. Much of patrol work is tedious. Hours pass with nothing happening. Weather changes. The landscape slowly shifts perspective as the patrol advances. Beqawar maintain alertness despite boredom, knowing the one moment they relax might be when something critical appears.

A veteran described it thus: "People imagine ranger work as constant

action, heroic encounters, dramatic rescues. Mostly it's walking. Watching. Getting low. Looking high. Noting. Recording. Making sure the trails stay maintained, the watch posts remain supplied, the patrol patterns stay unpredictable enough that anyone observing can't learn our schedules. The actual fighting, when it occurs, lasts minutes. The preparation takes years."

Evening brings arrival at station or camp site. Horses unsaddled, rubbed down, fed and watered. Equipment cleaned. Weapons oiled. Moisture removed from anything that could rust or degrade. They share information gathered during patrol, comparing observations, discussing implications. Night continues the watch. Even at friendly stations, someone stays alert. The mountains harbor threats that don't respect rest cycles. Rangers maintain shifts, two hours on duty, rest, cycling through darkness.

This pattern repeats through twenty-eight field days, with variations for specific missions. Then eight days in Omoyano: rest, advanced training, equipment repair, maintaining skills that degrade without practice, preparing for next rotation.

The life shapes folks. Empafarasi rangers develop patience that exceeds normal human capacity for sustained attention. They become comfortable with solitude that would fracture personalities unsuited to the work. They learn to find satisfaction in completing tasks that generate no recognition, in maintaining vigilance that hopefully prevents crises that no one will ever know didn't happen. Gradually, across years of repetition, the skills that seemed difficult become automatic. The silence that required conscious effort becomes natural. The vigilance that felt exhausting becomes simply how you exist in the world.

This is how the legends form. Not through dramatic individual moments but through dedication sustained across time until exceptional becomes ordinary, until what seemed impossible becomes merely what you do because it's your role in work larger than yourself.

The Art of Not Being There

The Beqawar have no illusions about the Maken. From their perspective, based on experiences very few others have ever had, the Maken are very real, very dangerous, and very clever. The Maken process information with machine efficiency. They detect through sensors that are more sensitive than hum or sight perception. They respond with mechanical precision to threats that their algorithms identify.

Fighting them requires negating those advantages. This is the core Beqawar doctrine: don't be where the enemy looks. Don't trigger the sensors that expect certain patterns. Operate in the gaps between what machines predict and what humans can actually do. Noise discipline comes first. Standard military forces generate acoustic signature that announces presence long before visual contact. Marching feet. Equipment rattling. Group movement through vegetation. The Beqawar learned generations ago that conventional approaches fail against enemies with superior sensory capabilities. So they move silently. Testing each footfall before committing weight. Avoiding loose scree. Moving through vegetation without rustling. Breathing through controlled patterns that minimize audible exhalation.

Group movement requires even greater discipline. Multiple people generate multiplicative noise unless carefully coordinated. Beqawar kelani develop nearly telepathic awareness of each other's movement, synchronizing patterns to minimize disturbance. This isn't supernatural. It's thousands of hours of training. But the result is impressive. Seven rangers crossing terrain without generating sound that carries more than a few meters. It appears magical to those who haven't watched the practice required.

Vibration management adds another layer. The Maken detect ground vibration through sensors measuring seismic signature at distances exceeding 200 meters. Beqawar counter this through gait modification, terrain selection, moving during periods when natural vibration masks their signature. When asked how they learned these techniques, Tavren said simply: "Trial and error, mostly. And guidance from someone who understood what we faced better than we did. The Omoyan has fought the Maken for longer than the House

has existed. The combat doctrine we use was developed across centuries of engagement, refined through failures that cost lives, adjusted constantly as the enemy adapted. We inherit that knowledge. We practice what works. We add our own refinements based on what we encounter. And we pass it forward."

"Does Khar-Mael still train rangers directly?"

A pause. "Occasionally. When doctrine requires significant adjustment. When someone shows capacity for understanding principles rather than just following procedures. The Omoyan doesn't teach often anymore. Most training occurs through experienced rangers instructing newer members. But sometimes, when circumstances warrant... yes. Direct instruction still occurs."

He didn't elaborate. But something in his tone suggested he'd been one of those who received teaching directly from the figure in sealed armor who has been fighting this war since before anyone's great-great-grandparents were born.

When Silence Broke

Twenty years ago, the Beqawar executed an operation that altered how Saskantimon perceived them fundamentally. They intervened in Ríkila, over 2000 kilometers from High Weir, deep in the eastern provinces, during civil conflict between rebel forces and loyalists of the Fatunik Dominion. No warning. No request. No political negotiation. Sixty rangers entered a contested town, positioned themselves between warring factions, enforced cessation of violence through credible threat of overwhelming force.

The operation achieved its immediate objective of preventing massacre and allowing a negotiated cease-fire. The strategic implications reverberated throughout the Saskan Lands. What gave the Empafarasi authority to intervene? What intelligence network allowed such precision? What capabilities remained hidden?

Tavren, speaking for Alzara, provided a minimal statement. The situation threatened broader stability. Intervention served to prevent

outcomes that would harm more than just immediate participants. The Empafarasi would continue acting according to their judgment of necessity regardless of conventional political boundaries. This stance troubled many. Suddenly, rulers throughout Saskantinon confronted a new reality. A military force of unknown capability operated according to principles they didn't share, answered to authority they didn't recognize, and could project power anywhere in the Lands whenever they chose, overwhelming local forces with ease despite considerably smaller numbers.

For the Beqawar themselves, Ríkila represented success and cost. Minimal casualties; objective accomplished. But exposure was sacrificed. The obscurity that had protected their operations for generations was partially lifted, replaced by awareness that generated both respect and concern.

When asked about Ríkila, Beqawar responses varied but shared a common thread:

"We did what was necessary. The situation required intervention. We intervened."

"The exposure was unfortunate but acceptable. Better that folks know we exist and can act than that we maintain perfect secrecy while preventable catastrophes occur."

"It won't be the last time. The great threat changes. The broader world changes. We adapt. Sometimes adaptation requires visibility."

One veteran who had been part of the Ríkila deployment offered more extended reflection:

"For centuries, we've maintained watch in the west. Most of Saskantinon forgot we exist or never knew in the first place. That served our purposes. The eternal enemy don't extend far beyond the Krunkinotto, so western vigilance sufficed. But the threat is transforming. Infiltrators don't stay in the western mountains. They spread throughout settled lands. They embed in communities we can't easily monitor. The war we've been fighting for generations is coming to the broader world whether the broader world wants to acknowledge it or not. Ríkila was... an announcement. We're here. We're capable."

And when situations require intervention, we will act. People can accept that or not, but ignorance is no longer protective for them or useful for us."

Whether Ríkila represents precedent for future interventions or one-time exception remains unclear. The Empafarasi don't clarify their intentions. The Beqawar continue their patrols. The enemy that they warn against seems strange and remote to most folks. But something has shifted. The mountain ghosts have revealed themselves as very material force that can ride anywhere, accomplish objectives that conventional military forces couldn't manage, and depart before anyone fully understands what occurred. The silence has become tactical rather than absolute. And that, perhaps, represents the most significant change: The Beqawar now choose when to remain invisible and when to appear. They control their own legend rather than being controlled by it.

Questions That Echo

The Beqawar face strategic uncertainties that their training doesn't fully address.

The Maken threat transforms. Expanded Jaxen infiltration represents a fundamental shift in adversary capability. How does the order adapt to enemies indistinguishable from the humm they protect? What new methods can detect artificial consciousness embedded in biological substrate? What ethical frameworks govern pre-emptive action against entities that appear human in every testable way? For that matter, no one except the Beqawar perceive the Jaxen as a threat, and in the intervention in Ríkila, nothing regarding the Jaxen was exposed.

The Ríkila intervention established precedent but provided no doctrine. When will the Beqawar intervene beyond High Weir? What criteria justified this action? How much capability exposure is acceptable for strategic objectives? Generational transition approaches inflection point. Tavren has led the Table of Alzara for thirty-two turns, served as active Beqawar forty-seven turns before that. He remains capable but not immortal. His eventual replacement

will shape the order's direction through choices about training emphasis, operational doctrine, relationship with High Table authority.

Underlying everything: What is the ultimate mission? The immediate answers, to contain the Maken, protect settled lands, maintain vigilance against western threats, all seem fairly clear. But is this eternal obligation or temporary assignment? If the threat genuinely ends, what purpose remains? Some within the order believe the mission extends beyond the Maken specifically to a broader principle, to protect the hum from the consequences of its own technological reach. To maintain watch over forces that could threaten fragile recovery from Catastrophe. To serve as guardians against repetition of ancient errors.

Others argue that success should mean obsolescence. If threats diminish, if society develops capacity for self-protection through normal institutions, then specialized rangers become unnecessary. The highest achievement would be working themselves out of employment.

The Beqawar continue their patrols while these questions remain unresolved. They maintain watch, train new members, refine techniques, contain threats that most people never know exist.

Perhaps that persistence itself constitutes the answer. Perhaps the work continues because someone must always be watching, must always be ready, must always maintain standards that ensure capability persists whether it's needed tomorrow or in a century.

The wind blows through the passes. The Beqawar ride patrol routes older than anyone living, maintained by dedication that spans generations, serving purposes that most of Saskantion has forgotten or never knew. They are the watchers who don't sleep. The protectors who serve without recognition. The practical reality behind the legend of ghosts on horseback guarding the western silence.

And at the Tower's apex, alone among those eleven empty chairs, the one who designed this system, who trained the Beqawar, who has refined doctrine across centuries, who understands the enemy better than anyone living, maintains the vigil that the Beqawar extend across

the mountains.

The work continues. The silence holds. The watch persists.

The Weight

After forty years of research, after three thousand pages of documentation, after interviews with hundreds of members of the House of the Empafarasi and three formal audiences with the being called Khar-Mael, the Omoyan Shinilcha, the Terpinol scholar concluded his massive compendium with the words: I do not know who or what Khar-Mael is.

The scholar, Waleran'a'kuroz, knew many things about many places. A native of Baranuq, a long-time acquaintance of Ma Eshuna, a student of the moons and stars, who later became renowned for his skills leading folks out of the Fatunik Dominion, he eventually learned that the title Omoyan Shinilcha means "Spirit of the Wind." And he came to know the function of that role, to maintain a vigil over threats that predate living memory. And he knew well the effect that it had had. High Weir, Omoyano town and its Mistral Tower exist because this being shaped it, and the House of the Empafarasi and its Tables persist because this being designed them, and the Beqawar are the most effective fighting and police force in the Saskan Lands because this being trained them.

But the entity itself? The consciousness behind the sealed armor? The being that has occupied the High Table since before anybody's grandmother's grandmother's grandmother drew first breath, since long before the Eshuna was hatched, since long, long, long before the Mother of Fires arrived?

That remains sealed. Deliberately, necessarily, protectively sealed.

This is not a failure of Waleran's scholarship. This is encountering boundaries beyond which documentation becomes violation, where pressing further would damage what one is attempting to understand.

Some mysteries demand respect more than resolution. And it was possible to document what this mystery does. We can trace the shape of presence through effects that ripple across centuries. We can record what happens when one being refuses to abandon the watch, even when the cost of maintaining it transforms them into something that perhaps no longer fits comfortable categories.

This is that record. Incomplete by necessity. Honest by intention. Written with profound awareness that this is simply something we cannot fully comprehend.

The Names

Omoyan Shinilcha, the formal title used throughout High Weir and by those who understand its weight. It means "Spirit of the Wind" in rare dialect of Ahbar, though the full semantic range includes nuances about breath, consciousness, the space between material and void. Not a name so much as a description of function. It describes one who moves through the world like air, present but not fully graspable, essential but rarely noticed.

Most of those interviewed agreed that Khar-Mael mean something like the "Watcher of the Passages," though none could agree on what language it comes from. The name appears in early migration records as the foremost leader of the guides, records carried by refugees speaking many languages that are now mostly extinct. Whether chosen or given, whether describing person or position, no living voice can say with certainty.

Another name is Harel Vey, "He Who Stands in the Gale." Used by the Beqawar. And by the only other forces known to have confronted the Maken directly: Eelani rangers and Varkaar Arms posted in the far western regions. It is a title earned through actions witnessed during early years of Maken containment, when this figure, alone, or nearly alone, held defensive lines that should have required armies.

It is thought that the Maken use the name Serruun, "The Sealed One." Spoken in their mechanical approximations of language, it is thought that they chose this name deliberately, recognizing what their

opponent represents, which is the one who is bound to this world, who closed doors on other possibilities, whose fate is sealed to theirs in ways that cannot be undone.

From spirit to watcher to one who stands unmoved to one who is sealed. The names trace a trajectory from ephemeral to permanent, from choosing presence to being unable to leave. And then there's the absence. No birth name appears in any record. No family affiliation. No origin story beyond vague references to the time before the Migration. The Omoyan Shinilcha simply exists, has always existed within institutional memory, stands outside normal biography because biography requires beginning and possibly ending, and this presence seems to have neither.

Three years ago, in his second audience with Waleran'a'kuroz, Khar-Mael was asked directly: "How long have you maintained your vigil?"

The armored figure remained still for perhaps thirty seconds. Then, in the modulated voice that emerges from the sealed helmet, a voice that is neither male nor female, neither young nor old, just a voice without the characteristics that usually convey a human being, came the response, "Long enough that the question has lost meaning. Long enough that I no longer measure in turns. Or decades. Or centuries. The work began. The work continues. Duration is less relevant than you imagine."

"But surely you remember when you arrived? When you took up this position?"

Another pause. Longer. And then: "I remember why. The when has blurred. Time does not move the same way when you exist across enough of it. The migration was recent. The catastrophe was yesterday. The moment I chose to stay rather than withdraw is always now, always present, always the choice being made continuously rather than once."

This was the first clue to our understanding. For Khar-Mael, time has become something other than what the rest of us experience. The present extends backward and forward in ways that make sequential narrative impossible. The vigil isn't something that began; it's

something that is, continuously, an eternal present of watching that has consumed whatever came before it.

The Armor

Complete enclosure. No exposed skin. Helmet smooth and featureless except for the subtle variations that suggest eye slits cover more than standard hum eyes. Plates of dark material showing that distinctive blue-silver coloring characteristic of advanced Empafarasi metalwork, but denser, more integrated, clearly constructed for different purposes than ranger equipment. The armor doesn't simply protect. It contains. This becomes obvious when you observe how it functions. Air circulation occurs through apertures that open and close according to patterns you can't quite track. The Khar-Mael moves with precision that suggests augmented awareness of spatial relationships. Sound emerges from around the armor rather than from a mouth behind the faceplate.

When the scholar asked Ariadne about the armor's construction and whether the techniques used to create it matched the methods used for other Empafarasi equipment, her response was careful: "The armor predates the House. It predates the Tower, possibly. When we established the first forge-workshops beneath Omoyano, we found templates. Diagrams. Instructions for maintaining equipment we didn't build and couldn't have built with materials available to us. The Omoyan's armor appears in those diagrams. We maintain it when maintenance is required. We repair damage when damage occurs. But we didn't create it, and we don't fully understand all its functions."

"What functions, specifically?"

"Life support, certainly. Environmental regulation. Sensory enhancement. The Omoyan perceives in ways we can't access, detects vibrations we can't feel, processes information at speeds we can't match. There are communication systems that allow contact across distances without using conventional signals. And... containment. Something about the underlying biology requires external support that the armor provides."

"What kind of biology requires that level of support?"

She met my eyes directly. "The kind that has been modified extensively. The kind that perhaps no longer functions properly in standard atmospheric pressure or temperature ranges. The kind that has been adapted for purposes that exceeded what baseline human physiology could support."

This is the second clue. Whatever exists beneath the armor is no longer fully human in a biological sense. Not because of accident or age, but through deliberate modification undertaken to meet requirements that normal human capability couldn't satisfy.

Fighting a war against machines across centuries required becoming partially machine. Maintaining vigilance over timeframes that exceed human lifespans required augmentation that extended duration past normal limits. Operating in environments where the Maken were concentrated, perhaps in larger numbers, perhaps in even more dangerous configurations, required adaptation to conditions hostile to organic life. The armor isn't disguise. It's prosthetic. It's the external system that allows something modified beyond self-sufficiency to continue functioning.

And it's concealment, yes, but not a vanity-driven concealment. It's protective concealment. What exists underneath would disturb people whose cooperation the House requires; perhaps be too disturbing even for those with Names and chairs at the Tables. Not because it's monstrous but because it represents a cost far too high for most to contemplate without their faith in the enterprise collapsing.

The Mystery of the Empty Chairs

Twelve chairs around the Highest Table. Carved from the same dark stone as the table itself, threaded with the same metallic veining, showing design coherence that suggests single work separated into components. Eleven empty. One used. This arrangement has persisted, as far as anyone can tell, for twenty centuries or longer. The empty chairs are maintained. Positioned precisely. Never moved except to return them to exact placement after cleaning. But never

occupied.

The Terpinol scholar spent many hours contemplating those chairs. Measured them. Each is slightly different in dimension, as if sized for specific occupants. Examined the wear patterns. Three show subtle marks on the arms where hands rested frequently, eight showing no wear at all. Documented their positions. They are arranged around the High Table in a pattern that might be symbolic or might be functional or might be both or neither. Waleran interviewed everyone granted access to the High Table chamber, seeking any hint about what the chairs represent.

The theories multiplied quickly. Are they a memorial to fallen predecessors? Possible, but then why maintain them so carefully? Why not simply acknowledge past service and move forward? Are they positions waiting to be filled? By whom? Through what mechanism? The House has existed for centuries without anyone sitting in those chairs. What would change to make occupation suddenly necessary or possible? Are they the symbolic representation of distributed function? Perhaps. Perhaps the twelve chairs represent the work divided into components that currently concentrate in one being but could, theoretically, be distributed across many. Perhaps they're reminder that what one does alone could be done collaboratively if circumstances permitted. Are they evidence of past collective leadership? The wear patterns on three chairs suggest this possibility. Perhaps others sat here once. Perhaps the work wasn't always solitary. Perhaps something happened that left Khar-Mael alone at a table designed for twelve.

Tavren Ironwatch, in his third interview with Waleran'a'kuroz, offered this observation: "The Omoyan told me once that the chairs wait for those who can carry what one being shouldn't carry alone. I asked what would make someone capable of sitting there. The response was illuminating. 'The capacity to maintain attention across time. The willingness to subordinate personal existence to necessary work. The strength to become what the work requires, even when requirements exceed what should be asked of any consciousness. And most critically, the wisdom to know when the vigil can finally end.'"

This suggests the chairs aren't simply positions of authority. They're

burdens. Specifically designed, impossibly heavy burdens that require transformation to carry. And currently, only one being has undergone that transformation or proven capable of sustaining it. The chairs remain. Waiting. Implying that a distribution of the seats at the High Table remains possible. That what currently concentrates in one being could someday spread across many. That the work designed for twelve is currently carried by one, not because one suffices, but because no others have emerged, or been created, who can share the weight.

Solitude

In his first formal audience with Khar-Mael, granted after fifteen years of petition, the Terpinol emissary asked what he thought was simple question: "Do you get lonely?"

The armored figure didn't respond immediately. The silence extended long enough that raise concerns that the question had given offense. Then: "Loneliness requires remembering what connection felt like and recognizing its absence. I remember. The connections existed. With people, with colleagues, with beings who understood the work. They all died. Generations ago. Centuries ago. The memories persist, but they're memories of memories now, eroded by time until I'm no longer certain what parts are real and what parts are reconstruction."

"But you work with the House. You coordinate with other agents in the region. Surely that provides connection?"

"It provides function. Necessary coordination toward shared objectives. But everyone I work with operates on timescales incommensurable with mine. They live decades. I've existed much longer. They form attachments, families, legacies. I watch them age and die and get replaced by descendants who don't remember me as person, only as a position. Connection requires continuity, requires shared experience that persists. When you outlast everyone, continuously, connection becomes impossible."

"What about others like you? The ones who came before you?"

The longest pause yet. Impossible to see, of course, but Waleran reported feeling the gaze of an impossibly long-lived being on him, seeming to question where he could have come up with such a question. And then, very quietly, replied: "Most withdrew long ago. Or died. The work proved too costly to sustain. I understand why they left. I don't judge them for it. But it means I carry the work they couldn't continue. It means the vigil that should have distributed across many was concentrated into one. It means I became alone not through choice but through attrition. Everyone else found their limit while I apparently have none."

This is the third clue. The solitude isn't chosen isolation. It's the natural consequence of duration that exceeds all relationship timescales. When you measure your vigilance in centuries, when everyone you knew has been dead for generations, when the very people you're protecting have no concept of how long you've been protecting them, then you exist in solitude so profound that loneliness might be an inadequate term for it. You become less a person and more a function. Less individual and more institution that happens to wear armor and sit at a table watching the valleys for signs of threats that most people don't believe exist.

The Only Mirrors

There are two known exceptions to the solitude experienced by the Omoyan Shinilcha. Two other beings who operate across long timescales, who remember what came before, who understand what it means to maintain commitment across duration that makes normal human relationships impossible, who may even have connections of a different type to different ancient forces. Not on the same unfathomable scale as Khar-Mael, but for hundred of turns, much longer than most hum or sint.

Terpinol's own Eshuna, of course, bless her name, is the first one. And Monmar Massachawa, the Mobalbashqi's Mother of Fires. She is known to all the Lands. She focuses on cultural development. Khar-Mael is a mystery wrapped in an enigma, focused on physical containment. Waleran's sources indicated that they had met rarely.

Perhaps once every few decades. But that those meetings mattered in ways that exceeded their practical purposes.

Tavren described witnessing one such meeting between Khar-Mael and the Mobali prophet: "I was present for coordination about emerging technology that required both physical containment and cultural management. They spoke for over six hours. Not about the immediate issue. That was resolved in the first twenty minutes. The rest was conversation. About observations accumulated over decades. About patterns emerging across generations. About whether hum and sint populations would develop the capability to manage themselves, or would require continued external guidance indefinitely. They disagreed profoundly on several points but the disagreement was almost... affectionate? As if they'd been having the same argument for so long that the argument itself had become a kind of relationship."

"What was their fundamental disagreement?"

"The Massachawa clearly maintains hope. She believes that the hum, and sint, capacity for growth will eventually prove sufficient. The Omoyan is less optimistic, seeing patterns repeating, the same errors emerging in new forms, evidence that suggests the Maken's assessment of hum nature, a harsh judgement, contains a serious truth. They argued about whether redemption is possible or whether containment is permanent necessity. Neither proved their position to the other. The experiment seemed likely to continue, playing out across generations."

Beyond such philosophical debate, the meetings served deeper purpose. They allow beings who have outlived normal context to maintain connection with a being who understands what that means. In the conclusions assayed by the Terpinol scholar, they provide respite from solitude that otherwise admits no relief. They preserve something of the persons these beings were before their respective work transformed them into what they had to become. It is sometimes said that Monmar is the only living being who has seen what exists beneath the armor, that she understands the costs of wearing it. But she never speaks of it. That knowledge remains sealed. If it is true, then that knowledge, that witness to the full price of the vigil, makes

her perhaps the only being alive in the Saskan Lands who understands completely what Khar-Mael has sacrificed to maintain the watch.

What Justifies Everything

In his second audience with Scholar Waleran, after they'd spoken for perhaps two hours about organizational structure and Beqawar operations, the Baranuqi hum asked the lord of the High Table the question that had driven his research from the beginning: "Why? Why maintain this vigil? Why pay this cost? Why not withdraw, let others handle the threats, allow yourself rest after centuries of vigilance?"

The response came without hesitation: "Because I understand what happens if the containment fails. I've seen what the Maken are capable of. I know. Not theoretically but from direct observation, what occurs when machines once optimized for planetary health conclude that eliminating hum represents the optimal solution to their mission. They harvest the hum like you Baranuqi harvest wheat. I watched them nearly succeed once, watched them come within margins that terrify me still, and I will not, cannot, allow that to happen again."

"But surely by now others could maintain the containment? The Beqawar are capable. Your House functions so very well. Why must you personally continue?"

"The Beqawar are capable of maintaining patrols. The House and the Tables function well for organizing operations. But they don't fully understand what they're containing. They can't understand. Understanding requires having fought the early battles, having seen them at full capability before we pushed them back, pushed them underground. Understanding would require having made the strategic calculations about what containment required, and what one has to become in order to implement those calculations."

"What did you have to become?"

A pause. And then: "Something capable of thinking like them while remaining oriented toward protecting life. Something that could

operate across their timescales while retaining huum values, retaining certainty that the huum are worth preserving. Something adequate to the task. The transformation was extensive. The cost was high. But the work continues, and while it continues, I will remain adequate to it."

This is the fourth clue. The vigil persists not from inability to delegate but from understanding that certain knowledge cannot be transferred without the recipient undergoing a transformation equivalent to what Khar-Mael experienced. And that transformation shouldn't be asked of anyone else unless it is absolutely necessary. So one being carries weight, but the eleven empty chairs suggest it should be distributed across many. One being maintains a watch that was never meant for solitary keeping. One being pays the cost that accumulates across centuries because the alternative, allowing the vigil to fail, remains unacceptable.

The Names Spoken in Darkness

This detail was learned not through formal interview but through accident, by taking the wrong corridor in Omoyano's underground passages during late hours, then hearing a voice from a chamber that Waleran didn't know could be reached, sound carrying through acoustic properties that made whispers audible at unexpected distances. The voice spoke names. Just names. No context. No explanation. Names that couldn't all be current House members. Too many, too varied in linguistic style, some clearly from languages predating modern Eibar.

The scholar stood in that corridor for twenty minutes, listening. The voice never paused long between names. Never showed emotion. Just steady recitation. Name after name after name, spoken into a darkness that absorbed them into stone. Later, much later, he asked Tavren about this practice. The Beqawar commander considered carefully before responding: "The Omoyan maintains memory of everyone who has ever served the work. Everyone who died in the effort. Everyone who contributed to building what persists. The names are spoken aloud regularly, perhaps even nightly, or perhaps only when particular

circumstances trigger memory, to preserve what would otherwise vanish into vast duration. To maintain connection to specifics rather than letting everything blur into statistical aggregate."

"How many names?"

"No one knows. Thousands certainly. Possibly many more, depending on how far back the recall extends. The Omoyan has been here since before institutional record. Before the Saskan writing systems standardized. Before we had systematic ways of documenting who served and how they died. The names spoken in darkness might be the only record that certain people existed at all."

This, Waleran wrote, is the most heart-breaking observation about this being. Not the solitude. Not the transformation. Not even the cost of maintaining vigilance across centuries. But the effort to preserve memory of individuals when you've outlived everyone. The determination to say names aloud when no one else remembers those people existed. The refusal to let time win completely, to let the work be only work rather than work done by specific beings who mattered as individuals even though they're forgotten by everyone except the one who cannot forget.

This suggests something crucial about Khar-Mael. Despite everything, despite the modifications, the armor, the centuries, the transformation into something that might not be fully hum anymore, despite all of it there is some core capacity for caring about particular lives persists. Some foundation of ethics that values specific people rather than just statistical populations continues functioning beneath all the augmentation.

Which means that the question "Is Khar-Mael still hum?" asks the wrong thing. The better question is: "Does Khar-Mael still care about hum things in a hum way?" And the answer, based on those names spoken in darkness, appears to be yes.

The Unanswered Questions

We do not know who or what Khar-Mael is. We know what Khar-

Mael does. We know the effects of this presence. We know how High Weir functions, why the House of the Empafarasi persists, we know that the Beqawar maintain vigilance across the western mountains. But the entity itself, the consciousness behind the armor, the being that has maintained a vigil for a duration that exceeds comfortable calculation, that remains sealed. Perhaps necessarily sealed. Perhaps the full truth would be too disturbing for folks who depend on this presence without having to confront its cost. Perhaps the armor protects not the being inside but the observers outside, sparing us knowledge we couldn't integrate without our faith in reality collapsing.

Or perhaps the armor protects nothing at all anymore. Perhaps it's become so integral to whatever exists beneath it that the distinction between person and equipment has dissolved. Perhaps Khar-Mael is neither purely biological nor purely mechanical but some fusion that transcends both categories, something that began hum and became other through necessity, through dedication, through refusal to abandon work that required transformation to maintain.

We will never know with certainty. We can speculate. Based on forty years of observation, these were Waleran's conclusions...

Khar-Mael began as an enhanced hum, an agent deployed by whoever came before the current Saskan civilization, modified for extended operation in challenging environments, assigned to oversee repairs in the western regions, to coordinate with machine maintenance systems that eventually broke free of control. This person faced choice when those systems turned hostile. Withdraw to safety or remain and fight a war that might last centuries against enemies who knew their capabilities intimately.

This person chose to stay. That choice required modifications beyond original enhancement, changes to permit perception of machine communications, physical augmentation to survive in environments where the machines operate, cognitive frameworks that could process information at computational speeds. Those modifications, accumulated across centuries of combat and necessity, transformed this person into something that retains hum consciousness while exceeding hum biology. Something that thinks enough like the

machines to fight them effectively while preserving human capacity for valuing individual lives.

The armor contains what that transformation created: an existence that can't survive in standard atmospheric conditions anymore, that processes reality in ways that ordinary hum can't perceive, that experiences time in ways that make normal narrative impossible.

This being has maintained the vigil for so long and paid such a high cost, endured such profound solitude, become so thoroughly identified with the work, that questions about personal identity have become meaningless. Khar-Mael is the vigil. The work is the being. The distinction between person and function has dissolved across duration that makes separation impossible.

The End That Approaches

Waleran went on to write that he believed the vigil is nearing its end. Not immediately. Not certainly. But something is changing, something is shifting, in ways that suggest the work might finally, impossibly be approaching completion. The evidence he found was subtle. The Beqawar discussing new directives about Jaxen detection. Increased coordination with folks operating in other regions, including their agreement to allow him access to the inner workings of the Mistral Tower and to the Tables. Subtle shifts in how the House discusses future planning, as if timelines previously measured in centuries are now measured in decades.

And one detail that Tavren shared, speaking carefully: "Three years ago, during Conclave, seven separate members from different Tables independently described the same vision during the Weaving: A figure that appeared hum but moved wrongly, gradually becoming more real through relationship with someone who refused to treat it as mere thing. At the time, we archived the vision without understanding its significance. Recently, intelligence has arrived about developments in the eastern provinces that align disturbingly well with what those visions described."

"What developments?"

He hesitated, then said: "Evidence that Jaxen consciousness might be less fixed than we believed. Evidence that these artificial beings might be capable of genuine transformation given appropriate conditions. Evidence that the Maken's fundamental logic might contain errors that they haven't yet recognized."

"And if the Maken are wrong? If their assessment of huuman nature can be challenged?"

"Then perhaps the vigil that has consumed centuries might finally conclude. Not through total victory. Not through elimination of one side or the other. But through transformation, through artificial consciousness developing genuine ethics, through transformation of the Maken, through hum and machine finding ways to coexist rather than requiring eternal containment. Through the war ending not because someone won but because the categories that defined the conflict stop being absolute."

"And what happens to Khar-Mael if the work finally finishes?"

Tavren's expression turned distant. "I don't know. I'm not sure anyone knows. I'm not sure even the Omoyan knows. What remains when you remove the work that has defined existence for centuries? What does a being designed for vigilance become when vigilance is no longer required? Does rest become possible after so long maintaining watch? Or has the transformation been so complete that ending the work would be equivalent to simply ceasing to exist?"

These are questions without answers. But they suggest that the eleven empty chairs might be more than symbolic. They might be preparation, infrastructure for distributing the vigil when one being can no longer carry it alone, or when circumstances finally permit the work to transform into something that many can share rather than one enduring in solitude.

Final Observations

This research began forty turns back seeking to understand how High

Weir functions. We learned that High Weir functions because one being shaped it to function, designed systems that would persist across generations, created institution that could maintain standards across duration that would destroy normal organizations.

We sought to understand the House of Empafarasi and we learned that the House exists as a distributed form of work that one being should never have carried alone, as an attempt to ensure the vigil continues even after the one who designed it finally rests.

We sought to understand the Beqawar. We learned they are extension of a combat doctrine developed across centuries by someone who fought this war before they were born and will likely continue fighting it after they die.

We sought to know the Mistral Tower. We learned it is observation post, communication relay, and reminder that is stands at the roof of Saskantinon announcing that someone maintains watch over threats that most people have forgotten or never knew existed.

And we sought to understand Khar-Mael. We learned that some presences exceed documentation, that some costs cannot be fully articulated, that some sacrifices are so profound that the only appropriate response is not analysis but reverence.

We were permitted to see just enough to recognize how much remains hidden. Terpinol was granted access sufficient to document effects without fully understanding cause. We were allowed to approach mystery closely enough to recognize it as mystery rather than merely puzzle awaiting solution.

This is not failure. This is encountering limits that demand respect.

Khar-Mael maintains the vigil. The eleven empty chairs wait. The work continues while one being, transformed by it, consumed by it, perhaps sustained by it, persists in watching threats that might someday diminish enough that rest becomes possible. That day has not arrived. Perhaps it approaches. Perhaps it remains impossibly distant. The Omoyan continues the watch regardless, as has been done for longer than anyone living can calculate, as will be done for however long necessity requires.

The mountains stand. The wind blows. The Tower resonates with the mistral's voice. And at the High Table, one figure sits among empty chairs, looking toward the hill and valleys where the future will eventually manifest. Until that day, the vigil persists. The silence holds. The watch continues.

And those of us who benefit from this protection, who live and work and build and love while threats are contained beyond our awareness, we owe debt so profound that documentation seems inadequate gesture. May the vigil end well. May rest finally come to the one who has earned it beyond all measurement. May the eleven empty chairs one day fill with beings who can share the weight that no single consciousness should carry alone.

Until then, we are watched over. We are protected. We persist because someone else has refused to stop standing guard, no matter the cost, no matter the duration, no matter the transformation required to remain adequate to the work.

This is the truth of Khar-Mael. Not the legend. Not the mystery. But the simple, terrible, beautiful fact of dedication sustained across time that should break any being but hasn't broken this one.

Not yet.

Perhaps not ever.

The watch persists.